

Taking the lead

A conductor's work on the rostrum is done through hand gestures, facial expressions, and movement of the whole body. The right hand generally provides the beat to indicate the basic pulse of the music, while the left hand concentrates on the expression. The first beat of each measure is indicated by a downbeat flick with the right hand. The remaining beats in the measure follow particular patterns.

LOOKING CLOSER

Baton

The conductor uses a baton to act as an extension of the arm. It is a narrow wooden or fiberglass rod, with a bulb at its wider end. It is usually held in the right hand, between the thumb and forefinger, with the bulb in the palm of the hand. Some conductors, especially when working with choirs, prefer to conduct using their hands alone.



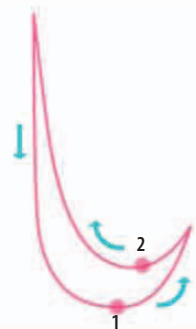
One in a measure

For one beat in a measure, the conductor makes a downbeat with the baton (or hand), flicking an imaginary "click" before bouncing back up immediately, ready for the next measure.



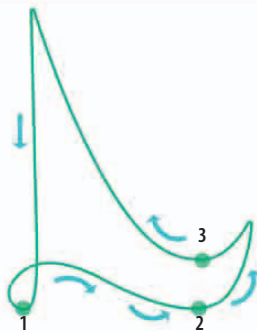
Two in a measure

For two beats in a measure, the conductor makes a downbeat with a click for the first beat and then repeats the click, bouncing the arm up again immediately, ready for the next measure.



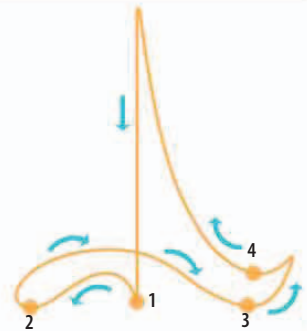
Three in a measure

After the first downbeat click, the conductor moves his arm to the right for the second click, flicking back toward the center for the third beat before returning to the top.



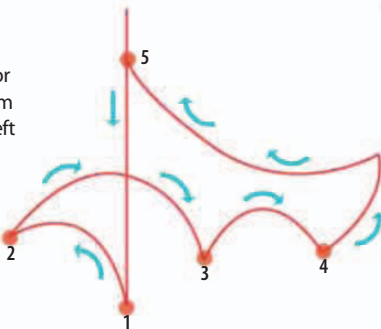
Four in a measure

After the first downbeat click, the conductor moves his arm to the left for the second click, across to the right for the third, flicking back slightly toward the center for the fourth beat before returning to the top, ready for the next measure.



Five in a measure

Five beats in a measure is unusual. The conductor begins by moving his arm down for the first beat, left for the second. For the third and fourth beats, he moves his arm to the right, then flicks upward for the fifth beat, before returning to the top for the next measure.



Six in a bar

After the first downbeat click, the second and third beats are clicks to the left, the fourth and fifth clicks are to the right, while the sixth is a final flick before returning to the top, ready for the next measure.

